Ticket priority and response-time targets (SLA)

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Summary

This article explains how Acme Global classifies incident tickets by priority (P1-P4) and the associated service-level agreement (SLA) response and resolution targets. It provides end-users with a self-help method to view the SLA timer on their tickets and gives Service Desk L1 agents a step-by-step procedure for assigning priorities, monitoring SLAs, and escalating when a breach is imminent.

Symptoms

- Users are unsure how long they should wait for a ticket to be addressed
- Tickets appear to remain open longer than expected without visible progress

Common causes

- Lack of awareness of the priority-based SLA matrix
- Inconsistent application of priority levels when tickets are created

Understanding Ticket Priority Levels and SLA Targets

Acme Global uses four priority levels that dictate how quickly the Service Desk must respond and resolve an issue. P1 (Critical) incidents require a response within 4?hours and resolution within 4?hours, with 24x7 phone support available. P2 (High) has an 8-hour response and resolution target. P3 (Moderate) allows 24?hours for both response and resolution. P4 (Low) permits up to 72?hours. These targets apply during standard business hours (Mon-Fri 08:00-20:00 IST) except for P1, which is supported around the clock via the phone extension 4357 (HELP).

Self-Help: How to Check the SLA Status of Your Ticket

When you submit a ticket through the IT self-service portal, the system automatically starts an SLA timer based on the priority you selected. You can monitor this timer to see how much time remains before the SLA expires. Knowing the remaining time helps you decide whether to add additional information or request an update.

1. Open a browser and go to the IT self-service portal at https://it.acme.example and sign in with your corporate credentials.
2. Click the "My Tickets" tab to view a list of your open and recent tickets.
3. Locate the ticket you want to check and click its number to open the detail view.
4. In the ticket detail pane, look for the SLA indicator - usually a bar or label showing "Time to Respond" and "Time to Resolve" with a countdown.
5. If the timer shows less than 30?minutes remaining, consider adding a comment with any new details or ask for an update using the "Add Comment" field.
6. If you believe the priority was set incorrectly, you can request a reassessment by commenting and tagging the Service Desk (e.g., @ITHelp).

Service Desk Agent Procedure: Assigning and Monitoring SLA

Agents must correctly assess the impact and urgency of each incoming incident to assign the appropriate priority. Once the priority is set, the ticketing system starts the SLA timer automatically. Continuous monitoring ensures that tickets are worked within the agreed windows and that escalations are triggered before a breach occurs.

1. Log into the ticketing system (ServiceNow) and open the new incident queue.
2. Read the description and any attached screenshots to determine the business impact: does the issue prevent critical services, affect many users, or cause minor inconvenience?
3. Select the priority level according to the matrix: P1 for organization-wide outage or safety issue, P2 for major degradation affecting a department, P3 for single-user or localized issue, P4 for general inquiry or low-impact request.
4. Save the ticket; the system will stamp the SLA start time and display the response and resolution deadlines.
5. Monitor the "SLA Dashboard" (or the "My Assignments" view with SLA columns) to see timers for all assigned tickets.
6. When a ticket's response timer reaches 50?% of its allowed time, send a proactive update to the requester.

7. If the resolution timer falls below one hour, immediately notify the relevant L2/L3 support group and document the escalation in the ticket's activity log.

Escalation Paths When SLA Is at Risk

When an agent recognizes that a ticket is unlikely to meet its SLA deadline, they must escalate promptly to avoid a breach. The escalation path depends on the priority level and the support group that owns the underlying technology. Including specific details in the escalation helps the receiving team act quickly.

Additional Resources and FAQs

For quick reference, the full SLA policy document is located on the Intranet at https://intranet.acme.example/policies/IT-SLA.pdf. The self-service portal FAQ includes a walkthrough on how to change a ticket's priority if you notice it was set incorrectly. If you need further assistance, contact the Service Desk via phone (4357), Teams chat, or the portal's "Request Help" button.

1. Open the closed ticket and review the "Closed" timestamp.
2. Compare the closed timestamp against the SLA deadline shown in the ticket's SLA fields.
3. If the closed time is on or before the deadline, mark the SLA as "Met"; otherwise, mark it as "Missed" and add a brief root-cause note.
4. Run the "SLA Compliance Report" (available under Reports -> Service Desk -> SLA) at the end of each week to see the percentage of tickets meeting targets per priority level.
5. Share the report with the Service Desk manager and discuss any recurring misses during the weekly ops meeting.

When to escalate

For P1 tickets, call the Phone Help line (extension 4357) and also post in the Teams channel "IT Help" with the ticket number, impact description, and current SLA timer. For P2-P4 tickets, create an escalation task in the ticketing system and assign it to the appropriate L2 group (e.g., Network Support, Desktop Support, Messaging & Collaboration). Include the following information: ticket ID, priority, SLA timestamps, steps already taken, logs or error messages, and any required access credentials. After escalation, set the ticket status to "Pending - L2" and continue to monitor for updates.

Keywords: SLA, ticket priority, P1, P2, P3, P4, response time, resolution target, escalation, self-service portal, ticket monitoring, Service Desk L1, priority matrix, IT help desk